

A FREE GUIDE FROM THE VERDICT WITH MARGO

5 health rules we all grew up with, *checked.*

The things our mothers, magazines and well-meaning friends told us. One rule at a time, held up against what the research actually says.

FALSE

IT DEPENDS

TRUE

with love, Margo

Hi, it's Margo.

For most of my life I followed health rules without asking where they came from. Eight glasses of water. Go easy on the eggs. Stop cracking your knuckles. Everyone said them, so they had to be true. Right?

Then I started looking them up. Not on forums, but in the reports and studies behind them. I spent the last six months reading, checking and rewriting, and I was surprised how many of the rules I grew up with don't hold up, and how many are more complicated than a one-liner.

This little guide is the first five. For each one you'll find the rule, what the research says, the fine print most headlines skip, and an honest verdict. The sources are listed on every page, so you never have to take my word for it.

One promise: no scare stories and no miracle cures. And one request: if something here touches your own health, take it to your doctor. A verdict about a rule is not advice about your body.

Margo

Five possible verdicts

TRUE

The research supports the rule as it's usually said.

FALSE

The research doesn't support the rule, or points the other way.

PARTLY TRUE

There's something real in it, but the popular version goes too far.

IT DEPENDS

The answer changes with the person, the amount or the situation.

NOT ENOUGH EVIDENCE

Nobody knows yet. Anyone who sounds certain is guessing.

Not every rule is a myth. Sometimes Grandma was right. The point isn't to prove anyone wrong, it's to know what we actually know.

“Drink eight glasses of water a day.”

OI

We’ve all heard it. Some of us carry the bottle to prove it.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In 2004 the US National Academies reviewed the evidence on water and set official guidelines. Their conclusion: most healthy people get enough water by drinking as they normally do and letting thirst guide them. They deliberately did not set a rule for a number of glasses.

Their general guide for *total* water, from all drinks and food together, is about 2.7 liters a day for women and 3.7 liters for men. And about 20% of the water we take in usually comes from food: soup, fruit, vegetables. Coffee and tea count too.

The fine print. Hot weather, hard physical work and some medical conditions change how much you need. If you have a heart or kidney condition, or take medicine that affects fluids, ask your doctor for your own number.

FALSE

as a must-follow rule for healthy people

Source: National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine. Report on Dietary Reference Intakes for Water, Potassium, Sodium, Chloride, and Sulfate, press release, February 2004.

“Coffee dehydrates you.”

Usually followed by: “so drink an extra glass of water for every cup.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

A 2014 study tested exactly this. Fifty men who drank coffee every day spent three days drinking four cups of coffee a day (about 200 ml each), and three days drinking the same amount of water instead. Their hydration measures came out about the same either way.

The National Academies also count caffeinated drinks toward your daily fluid intake.

The fine print. The study included only men aged 18 to 46, only people used to coffee, and a moderate dose. If you rarely drink coffee, or drink a lot of it, the result may not apply to you.

FALSE

for regular, moderate coffee drinkers

Sources: Killer S.C., Blannin A.K., Jeukendrup A.E. “No evidence of dehydration with moderate daily coffee intake: a counterbalanced cross-over study in a free-living population.” PLOS ONE, 2014. · National Academies, 2004 (see rule one).

“Cracking your knuckles gives you arthritis.”

Said by every grandmother, at every family dinner.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

One doctor, Donald Unger, decided to find out on himself. For about sixty years he cracked the knuckles of his left hand and left his right hand alone. At the end, X-rays showed no arthritis in either hand and no difference between them.

One man is not a big study. But according to Arthritis UK, other research hasn't found a link either. One older study of about 300 people did find that habitual knuckle-crackers had more hand swelling and a weaker grip.

The fine print. No link to arthritis is not a reason to crack all day. And if a joint hurts or swells when it clicks, have it checked.

FALSE

no link to arthritis has been found

Sources: Arthritis UK (Versus Arthritis), “Does cracking your knuckles cause arthritis?” · Unger D.L. “Does knuckle cracking lead to arthritis of the fingers?” Arthritis & Rheumatism, 1998.

“You need less sleep as you get older.”

We start waking at five and decide that’s just how it is now.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

The CDC recommends at least 7 hours a night for adults 18 to 60, 7 to 9 hours for ages 61 to 64, and 7 to 8 hours from 65 on. That’s barely different from younger adults.

What does change is the sleep itself. According to MedlinePlus, sleep with age tends to become lighter, with more waking during the night and earlier in the morning. So many of us *get* less sleep. That’s not the same as *needing* less.

The fine print. If you’re tired during the day, tell your doctor rather than accepting it as part of aging.

FALSE

the need stays about the same; sleep gets lighter

Sources: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), “About Sleep.” · MedlinePlus (US National Library of Medicine), “Aging changes in sleep.”

“Eggs are bad for your heart.”

05

The yolk was the villain for decades. The advice changed, and many of us missed it.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In 2020 the American Heart Association reviewed the evidence on cholesterol in food. Large studies following people over time mostly did not find a clear link between dietary cholesterol and heart disease.

But controlled studies show that eating much more cholesterol than average can raise LDL, the “bad” cholesterol. So the advice moved away from counting milligrams and toward your overall way of eating: vegetables, fruit, whole grains, nuts and plant oils.

The fine print. If your doctor is already managing your cholesterol, ask what fits you. This isn't a number-of-eggs answer.

IT DEPENDS

on the amount and your overall diet

Source: Carson J.A.S. et al. “Dietary Cholesterol and Cardiovascular Risk: A Science Advisory From the American Heart Association.” *Circulation*, 2020.

Which one surprised you?

Tell me in my DMs. I read every message, and the rules you send me are the ones I check next.

A new verdict every week.

Follow **@verdictwithmargo** on Instagram, and send this guide to a friend who still believes all five.

Please read. This guide is general information for curious adults, not medical advice, diagnosis or treatment. It doesn't replace a conversation with your doctor or pharmacist. Research changes; these summaries reflect the sources listed on each page as of October 2026. If you have a health condition, take medicine, or are unsure whether something applies to you, ask a qualified professional before changing anything.